

What You Need, What It Is

Storage Space: If you're building a site that's mostly text, even a 500 MB hosting plan will do. For many hosts, the average is around 5 GB, which is quite ample.

Bandwidth: This is the amount of data transfer allowed to and from your site. If someone downloads a 400 KB image from your site, for example, you've used up 400 KB of your bandwidth. You'll usually be well under your bandwidth limit (mostly around 25 GB or so) in your site's early days.

Content Platform: The language that your site's content is written in. PHP is standard for a CMS, so hosts that don't support it should be crossed off your list. You might have to pay extra for Ruby on Rails support—the platform has started to gain a lot of attention. It's not as hassle-free as PHP, though.

Databases: Where PHP is standard for content, MySQL is the standard for

databases. Look for a host that offers at least five free MySQL databases with their plan. Beware of some Indian hosts: their plans might look attractive, but you'll have to cough up extra for each new database.

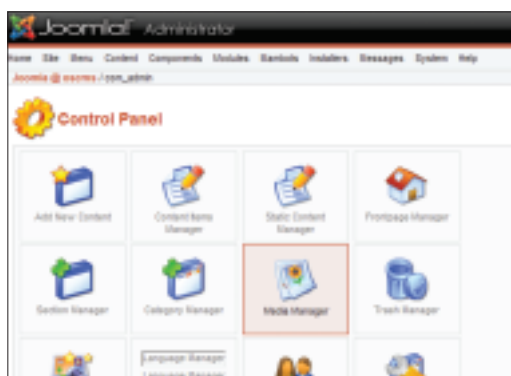
Overselling: One of the universal truths of hosting: just like hotels overbook rooms and airlines overbook flights hoping that someone will decide not to show up, Web hosts sell you storage space and bandwidth hoping that you won't use it all up. They might sell 5 GB of space to ten people, but host all those sites on a 20 GB hard drive. It's a relatively safe bet—for a small business site, even 500 MB is a lot, so no upper limits might be hit. Just remember that *everybody* oversells—that's how they get their plans to look so attractive.

cPanel: This is a site administration control panel that's filled to the gills with features, and is very easy to use.

Among other things, it features Fantastico, an installation script that automates the installation of a variety of CMSes.

Load Balancing: This is a feature of more expensive hosting plans: your site is hosted on two different servers, so visitors are intelligently directed to the one that has less load. In addition, if your site has to be updated, it's done one server at a time, so the site itself is never down.

Shared Hosting: Like the term implies, this means that your site won't be the only one hosted on the server. This is your best choice in the beginning, when your site isn't getting bombarded with traffic. Once visitors to the site increase—or if you face performance hassles—you can consider moving to dedicated hosting, where you'll be the only site on a particular server (naturally, this is more expensive).



Joomla's (top) graphical administration is easier to get used to than Drupal's (above) minimalistic approach

people sign up for e-mail on your site, they'll see the familiar Gmail interface (complete with the counter that shows them how big their inbox is getting), but they'll have an address that ends with @yourdomain.com. You'll also get all the other natural goodness that Gmail offers—rugged spam protection, IMAP access

and integration with Google Calendar. If you pay for the Premier Edition (\$50 per account per year, with 25 GB storage for each), you even get a 99.9 per cent uptime guarantee and 24-hour support.

If visitors need to know your schedule for upcoming weeks or months, you can use Google Calendar to publish them. Thanks to configurable access restrictions, you can choose to show visitors only when you're free or busy, and hide the information about the actual event. If you're working with someone who you can't meet with every day, Calendar becomes an invaluable collaboration tool as well. Also included in the package are Google Docs and Spreadsheets, though they'll be more useful to you and your team than to your visitors.

Some Random Wisdom

You can check out demos of Joomla and Drupal at OpenSourceCMS (www.opensourcecms.com) to see how they suit you, but we recommend actually downloading and setting it up on your PC using software like WAMP, which installs Apache, PHP and MySQL to your Windows PC, then uploading the lot. If you've chosen cPanel hosting, you don't even need to do that—just use Fantastico to install the CMS you want and start building your site. If you decide halfway through not to use it any more, you can uninstall it just as easily.

Finally, always get yourself a .com domain—nearly everyone uses the [Ctrl] + [Enter] combination when they enter URLs (thinkdigit + [Ctrl] + [Enter] takes you to www.thinkdigit.com in any browser, for instance), so if you get yourself, say, a .net domain, you're just making visitors type four characters extra, and nobody wants that. ■

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